

Let's look at why that might be.

First, Americans had a huge resource advantage. Arriving in the new world, they found forests that had never been touched by the saw, rich earth that had never been turned by the plow, native peoples who had never been murdered or exploited. Each time the land wore out or got crowded, they picked up stakes and moved West.

Abraham Lincoln described why his family left Kentucky for Illinois: Kentucky had gotten crowded and, he explained, "you could hardly go 10 miles in any direction without seeing the smoke from a neighbor's campfire."

This three-century push to the West gave American settlers an expansive sense of optimism. The further they went, the greater the wonders they discovered. From sea to shining sea, there were mountains and forests—land, land, land—and then, when they finally got to the shining sea on the West Coast, they found a remarkable country where almost everything would grow. They found valleys they could plant and waves they could surf.

That was the story of the United States from the seventeenth century to the end of the nineteenth and into the twentieth century, too. Onward and upward—better and better, year after year.

Now, the country is still thinly populated, compared with other parts of the world. But with 300 million people, it is no longer virgin territory. Neither are its land nor its water as limitless as they once appeared. Even its human resources are slowing and aging. Immigration into the United States is at a 20-year low. The population is growing at the slowest rate since before the Baby Boomers were born.

Wood and coal powered the first phase of U.S. growth and expansion. Wood was the fuel of choice in the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries. America had it. More trees than you could cut. More wood than you could burn. The Old World did not. The forests of Europe had been reduced by centuries of cutting. The country side was relatively crowded. It needed farmland, not woodland.

Then came coal and oil. Discovered commercially in Pennsylvania, oil packed much more energy into an even more dense and convenient form.